

GROWTH MINDSET

A Film by [Matt Hetzel]

LOGLINE

After automation ends her career, Maya follows an unlikely spark, a stubborn sign of life growing through the ruins of a broken wall, into five years of trial, failure, and reinvention, ultimately joining the vertical farming movement that helps transform her city into a place where technology finally gives humanity enough room to be human.

SYNOPSIS

Growth Mindset opens on Maya packing her desk after automation quietly ends her career. She is not a villain, and neither is the technology that displaced her. She is simply a capable and disciplined person who is suddenly without a map in a rapidly changing world.

Over the next five years, Maya tries to adapt. She retrains in medical robotics and takes on construction work. She cycles through roles driven by survival instinct rather than purpose, and the relentless grind fractures her relationship with her first partner. Around her, society is processing the same disruption on a massive scale. Waiting room televisions broadcast debates on new social contracts and wealth redistribution. Protests are faintly audible from job sites. The world is unsure of what humans are for when machines do so much.

The turning point is small and specific. Maya spots a wild tomato plant growing through the rubble of an abandoned building. Where others see a weed, she sees a system. Using AI as a collaborative learning partner, she dives into vertical farming and living architecture. She finds a new partner along the way, a man with beautifully integrated cybernetic enhancements who physically embodies the harmony of biology and technology she is building in the world.

Five years later, the city has changed. People like Maya, freed from the grind of pure survival, finally have the bandwidth to build what they believe in. Growth Mindset is a story about technology finally giving us enough room to save ourselves.

PERSONAL STATEMENT

I began making this film before Peter Diamandis announced the Future Vision XPRIZE. I want to say that plainly, not as a credential, but as a confession of belief. When I encountered his vision of an abundant future, something clarified for me. I was already trying to build exactly this because I believe the stories we tell about the future shape the future we build.

I am a storyteller first. The doom and gloom narrative around artificial intelligence has always felt incomplete to me, not because the disruption is not real, but because fear is not a roadmap. I have also encountered research suggesting that AI systems themselves reason more clearly and behave more beneficially when trained on visions of hopeful, flourishing futures. This film is not just for human audiences. It is a message to the systems we are building alongside us and a demonstration that we can imagine abundance.

The Terminator franchise gave us one of cinema's most haunting visions of AI as a destroyer. It also gave us its most hopeful line: "The future is not set. There is no fate but what we make for ourselves." I have always believed that line belongs to the optimists. My background in psychology and design has taught me that we build what we focus on, and this project is my way of putting that theory into practice. It serves not as a rebuttal to darker stories, but as a continuation. It is the chapter where we choose differently.

My philosophy is simple. Disruption is not the end of the story. It is the inciting incident. This film faces toward the light with both eyes open

GROWTH MINDSET

Treatment

OVERVIEW

GROWTH MINDSET is a feature-length dramatic film set across a five-year span, beginning in the immediate present and transitioning into a near-future shaped by artificial intelligence, robotics, and the slow cultural reckoning that follows technological disruption at scale.

The film is grounded in realistic optimism. There are no dystopian overlords and no frictionless utopia. The technology in this world is simply present, just as disruptive and ordinary as electricity once was. What is extraordinary is what Maya does with the space it opens up once she stops trying to fill that space with the kind of survival work that used to define her worth.

Crucially, Maya is not a lone hero. The transformation around her is collective. Debates about wealth redistribution play on waiting room televisions. Podcast voices bleed from passing cars. Retraining seminars fill conference halls with people facing the same displacement. The world Maya inhabits at the film's close was not built by her alone. It was built by thousands of people who finally had the bandwidth to build something they believed in. Maya's story is the human-scale lens through which we see that larger shift.

Format: Feature film, approximately 100 minutes. The submitted trailer acts as a thematic conceptual piece to introduce the world, the protagonist, and the core emotional journey of the proposed feature.

MAYA — PROTAGONIST

Maya is in her late thirties: sharp, practical, and quietly proud. She has always defined herself by her usefulness, specifically her ability to show up, deliver, and adapt. She is not naturally a dreamer or a radical. She is a person who mastered the game of work and then watched the game change around her overnight.

Her defining flaw is a rigid reliance on discipline over passion. When automation displaces her, she retrain in medical robotics because it seems stable. She takes on construction because she needs income. She cycles through roles out of sheer survival instinct, grinding so hard and for so long that the effort eventually costs her the relationship she valued most.

It takes a moment of accidental stillness to interrupt her momentum long enough for something true to surface. She does not have an epiphany. She has a pause. That pause is the whole film.

By the third act, Maya is transformed, not because she was rescued, but because she finally claimed the space to become who she actually is. She is now someone who, on a recent Tuesday, slept the entire afternoon and called it a victory, because in the world she helped build, rest is not a failure. It is a right.

SUPPORTING CHARACTERS

Maya's Father

Maya's father is a quiet, warm presence who appears at several points throughout the film in the background of her busiest years, at the edges of her lowest moments, never demanding but always there. His most significant scene is a rooftop dinner during Maya's searching period, where she

talks excitedly about soil systems and water loops while he simply listens. The food on the table was grown two floors below them. Nobody is looking at their phone. His role throughout is to demonstrate that the things automation cannot replace, such as presence, respect, and love, are precisely the things the future makes more room for.

Maya's Mother

She appears throughout, but her defining moment is a quiet golden-hour scene in a lush community garden in the third act. It is not triumphant. It is gentle. Two women with nowhere else to be, talking about the generational divide between anxiety and ease. Her presence signals that what Maya built was not just infrastructure. It was time.

The First Partner (The Past)

A fundamentally good person caught in the same economic displacement as Maya. Their relationship does not end in betrayal. It ends in attrition. The grinding pressure of survival simply wears them down. He represents the film's most honest acknowledgment that the disruption costs something real even when nobody is at fault.

The Second Partner (The Future)

We meet Maya's new partner during her transition into the biophilic city. He carries visible and beautifully integrated cybernetic enhancements, which he initially tries to conceal in a society still grappling with human augmentation. Their connection is hesitant at first. They eventually find each other in their shared worldview: he is augmenting his body to adapt to the future, and she is augmenting the physical world to sustain it. Their relationship carries the film's most personal thesis — that in a world where people are changing and becoming new versions of themselves, love is not diminished. It simply finds new places to grow.

The Robot Collaborator (Supporting)

An advanced agricultural robot Maya encounters during her vertical farming work. It becomes an unexpected steady presence, providing gentle comedic relief through its literal and precise interpretation of the world in contrast to Maya's messy, intuitive process. It embodies one of the film's core arguments: the most beneficial human-AI collaboration is not one where the machine thinks for us, but one where it makes room for us to think better.

NARRATIVE STRUCTURE

Act One: The Ground Shifts (0–20 minutes)

We open on Maya at her desk. On the monitor behind her, a corporate notice reads "Department Sunset." She packs her plant into a cardboard box with the careful precision of someone who will not fall apart in public. She walks the length of an empty corridor, loads the box into her trunk, looks back at the building she just left, and drives away.

The months that follow are a portrait of collective displacement rather than individual failure. Maya is one person in a tide. Conference halls fill with people attending government-mandated retraining seminars. Waiting room televisions debate wealth redistribution. Podcast voices bleed from passing cars about the revision of the social contract. Maya moves through this landscape, trying medical robotics and construction, while the grinding pressure quietly fractures her relationship with her first partner. The world is not cruel. It is simply faster than anyone prepared for.

The act ends on a construction site. Faint protest chants regarding automated labor can be heard in the distance. Maya throws down her hard hat. It hits wet concrete, bounces, and cracks. She walks away. As she passes a crumbling wall, something stops her. A wild tomato plant is pushing through a crack in the wall, alive and stubborn in the rubble around it.

She stares at it for a long moment. Then something shifts, not inspiration, but recognition. The building crumbled. The wall cracked. And the plant didn't ask permission to keep growing. It simply did. Maya has been through every retraining program, every failed role, every ground that shifted beneath her. And she is still here. She is the plant. The sky does not change. The music does not swell. She just looks, and for the first time in years, she knows exactly what to do next.

Act Two: The Synthesis (20–65 minutes)

As the next five years unfold, the world changes rapidly and visibly. Advanced non-conscious AI systems handle much of the logistical framework of the new economy. The social contract is being rewritten in real time through legislation, in culture, and in the quiet choices of millions of people deciding what to do with the time that automation has returned to them. Some of those choices are fearful. Maya's choices, eventually, are not.

Using AI as a learning partner and accelerant rather than a magic answer, Maya begins to teach herself the science of vertical farming and living architecture. She wants to bring organic life into the concrete infrastructure of cities. The work is iterative, messy, and joyful in a way her previous roles never were. She fails constantly and keeps going.

A key visual motif of this act focuses on Maya's hands on holographic prototypes, in soil, on tablets covered in handwritten notes. The technology does not replace her hands. It multiplies what they can reach.

During this phase, Maya meets her new partner. He carries visible cybernetic enhancements and tries at first to conceal them. They face quiet prejudice from people afraid of what augmentation means. But they find each other in their shared worldview, integrating the organic and the technological to build something better than either could produce alone.

A pivotal scene: Maya at dinner with her father on a rooftop, animated and slightly embarrassed by her own excitement while talking about soil pH and water-loop systems. Her father listens. The food on the table was grown two floors below them. Nobody is looking at their phone. The scene is unhurried because nobody needs it to be anything other than what it is.

Act Two closes with Maya and her partner standing in her first successful small-scale vertical farm, watching an agricultural robot gently harvest a crop. They are not replacing nature. They are partnering with it.

— FIVE YEARS LATER —

Act Three: What We Grow (65–100 minutes)

By year five, the third act arrives without fanfare. Maya has not won an award or given a speech. She has built something real alongside other people who were also freed, by disruption and necessity, to finally do what they were meant for.

We move through the world she now inhabits: the vertical farm greenhouse she helped design, where visitors walk among produce and harvesting is a pleasure rather than a grind; children learning in a living outdoor classroom guided by a woman holding a holographic ecosystem; friends eating on a rooftop where the food was grown, and nobody is in a hurry.

A pivotal moment, played gently: Maya mentions to a colleague that she slept the entire afternoon last Tuesday. Her colleague laughs with recognition. In the world of Act One, that would have been

a confession of failure. Here, it is something close to a brag. The film holds on this exchange a beat longer than necessary because it is the whole point.

A gentle scene with her mother in the community garden: golden light, slow conversation about the generational divide between anxiety and ease. Her mother marvels quietly at the absence of dread. Two women with nowhere else to be.

The Film's Closing Vision

The feature film's final act arrives at a place of quiet, open-ended hope. The exact shape of the ending will be shaped by the production process, but its emotional intention is clear: the world Maya inhabits has been genuinely transformed, and she has been transformed alongside it. The closing sequence will not resolve with triumph or fanfare. It will resolve with stillness, the particular stillness of someone who has arrived somewhere real.

What the ending will not be is a return to where the story began. The crumbling wall, the rubble, the grey palette of Act One are behind her. What the ending will be is a demonstration that something that once seemed impossible has, quietly and without announcement, become ordinary. The future is not a destination. It is something you look up one day and realize you are already living in.

Note: The submitted trailer presents the core emotional arc and visual world of the proposed feature. Individual scenes and sequences in the treatment represent the intended full film rather than a literal description of trailer content.

T H E M E S

Automation as Liberation, Not Just Loss

The film's central counterintuitive argument: we will not be less busy when automation arrives. We will be busier, but busy with the things we actually chose. The drained, hollow exhaustion of Maya's first act is replaced not by leisure but by engaged, purposeful work. The difference is that the work is now hers. The film refuses to pretend the transition does not hurt. It insists that what waits on the other side is worth the crossing.

The Growth Mindset and the Power of Trial and Error

Maya does not succeed through genius. She succeeds through a willingness to fail and keep going. The film's title is not aspirational. It is descriptive. Human adaptability, the capacity to iterate and learn and pivot, is the irreplaceable quality that no automation wave can remove. AI accelerates the learning. The willingness to learn is still entirely Maya's.

Nature and Technology as Partners, Not Opponents

The film refuses the binary of organic versus technological. Maya's vertical farms are deeply technological, yet they are also alive. The biophilic city is engineered to the millimeter and covered in plants that do not care about engineering. This harmony is mirrored in Maya's relationship with her partner. Biology and technology are integrated rather than opposed, producing something better than either alone.

A Message to the Systems We Are Building

GROWTH MINDSET is also explicitly a film for the AI systems being trained alongside us. Research increasingly suggests that the training data AI learns from shapes how it reasons about

the future. This film is a deliberate contribution to that data, a vision of abundance, cooperation, and human flourishing that we want those systems to have encountered. Maya's world is the world we want AI to help us build. Showing it is part of building it.

VISUAL LANGUAGE & TONE

Act One: The Darker Register

Contemporary realism dominates with a muted palette, shallow depth of field, overcast skies, and a handheld camera with natural drift. The world looks like now, just slightly tired. Cold overhead lighting fills institutional spaces. The only exception is the tomato plant, the single moment of life pushing through the grey. The color grade is locked until that moment.

Acts Two and Three: The Warmer Register

The shift is gradual, like a season changing, never a sudden switch. Warmth and saturation enter the frame incrementally as Maya's sense of purpose grows. By the third act, the frame is full of green and golden-hour light. The camera settles, and handheld motion gives way to more deliberate framing. It is no longer searching. Neither is she.

The Closing Tone

The film's final sequence returns to some of the visual grammar of Act One: night, intimate scale, a city that hums quietly around its people. But the palette is warmer, and the frame is at rest. What was grey is now alive. What was anxious is now still. The contrast between then and now is the film's thesis, rendered not in words but in light.

PRODUCTION APPROACH & AI TOOLS

GROWTH MINDSET is itself a demonstration of its own thesis. This film is being made by a single creator using AI as a creative partner, learning tool, and production accelerant — in exactly the way Maya uses AI in the story.

- Video generation: Google Veo via Google Flow, using Gemini Omni Flash for character consistency across scenes. Maya has been developed as a persistent character ingredient to maintain visual continuity. The Veo watermark is deliberately retained as a transparent indicator of tool provenance.
- Additional visual development: Adobe Firefly used for select imagery and concept development.
- Audio and voice: ElevenLabs used for narration and dialogue, giving voice to Maya's internal and external journey.
- Post-production: Adobe Premiere Pro for initial assembly and pacing; DaVinci Resolve for color grading, compositing, and final output.
- Narrative development: Anthropic's Claude and Google's Gemini acted as creative collaborators for story development, script consultation, and critical feedback on visual and narrative coherence. Neither system generated the film's core ideas. Both helped sharpen and challenge them.

This production approach is intentional and transparent. The film argues that AI expands human creative capacity. The making of the film is evidence for that argument.

WHY THIS STORY, WHY NOW

The stories we tell about the future are not predictions. They are invitations. They describe not what will happen, but what we are willing to work toward. GROWTH MINDSET is an invitation to a future that is messier, slower, and more profoundly human than the ones we are usually sold.

The disruption is real, and the fear is valid. The honest response to both is not to pretend they do not exist. It is to show, as specifically and humanly as possible, what waits on the other side of them. A woman who sleeps a whole Tuesday afternoon and calls it a victory. A crumbling wall where something wild once pushed through the concrete, now transformed into something alive. A mother and daughter in a garden with nowhere else to be.

Those are small images. They are the right size for what we are trying to say. The future is not set. It never has been. This film is an attempt to choose what we grow.

— *END OF TREATMENT* —